"The ECI is afraid the poll process would be misled by fake votes in the name of dead, duplicate, fake and foreign voters. That is why this revision has been launched in Bihar and will be taken to the entire country"

GYANESH KUMAR
Chief Election Commissioner



"By sharpening the demographic debate, the Modi government is clearly eyeing the upcoming assembly elections in Bihar, Assam and West Bengal"

JAIRAM RAMESH
General Secretary in-charge Communications, Congress

Photographs: ANI

filtration in strife-torn Manipur to praising Assam's eviction drives against "encroachers". In Bihar's eastern Seemanchal belt, where Muslims constitute over 60 per cent of the population in some districts, he sharpened the BJP's allegation of demographic change driven by infiltration.

RSS ideologue and India Foundation founder Ram Madhav echoed the intent behind the demography mission when he framed the project in historical and geopolitical terms. India's first census in 1951, he said, doubled as a de facto citizens' register. Eight decades later, with an unsettled neighbourhood dominated by theocratic regimes, tracking demographic changes driven by illegal immigration has become a pressing need. Whether this takes the form of another nationwide NRC (National Register of Citizens) or a different mechanism, Madhav suggests, will be decided by the demography mission.

Meanwhile, there have been other quiet developments. Five months earlier, Parliament passed the Immigration and Foreigners Bill, 2025, which merged four colonial-era laws into a single statute. The new framework gives sweeping powers to the Bureau of Immigration to identify and deport illegal migrants. The law came into force on September 1. The next day, the Union ministry of home affairs (MHA) directed all states and Union Territories to set up holding centres or detention camps to confine suspected illegal foreigners until deportation.

Seen in the context of these developments, the plan for the national SIR signals the BJP's return to core themes that have defined its national project since 2014: hardening citizenship boundaries and aligning legal frameworks with a political narrative that views demographic change as an existential threat to the Republic. For more than a decade, the BJP's most consistent refrain has been 'infiltration', the claim that undocumented migrants, largely from Bangladesh (and Rohingya entering through it), have crossed in such numbers that they are reshaping the religious, linguistic and electoral character of large parts of India.

In 2019, the NRC in Assam had become the movement's administrative showcase. Union home minister Amit Shah sharpened the rhetoric further, first describing infiltrators as "termites" and later unveiling the 'chronology'—the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) followed by a nationwide NRC. Together, these declarations crystallised fears among India's 200 million Muslims that they were being systematically singled out. The SIR, critics claim, is the repackaged NRC. "There is a definite element of the NRC in the SIR exercise, given the EC's insistence on checking citizenship and its extreme reluctance to accept Aadhaar," says political activist Yogendra Yadav. Others strongly contest this view. "Verification exercises conducted by legitimate authorities are both justified and necessary," says Prof. Vandana Mishra, Centre for Political Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University. "Under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, the Election Commission has clear powers to carry out such verification while preparing electoral rolls. Moreover, the very inclusion of a person's name in the electoral roll presupposes that they possess the requisite documents to establish nationality."

Who is a Citizen?

Citizenship in India has always been a layered question, both legal and personal. The Constitution, when it came into force on January 26, 1950, drew the first boundaries of belonging. Anyone domiciled in India at that moment could be a citizen if they were born in the territory, had a parent born there, or had lived there continuously for five years. The framers had to deal with the turbulent backdrop of Partition, and so they crafted rules for those who migrated from Pakistan—granting citizenship to those who crossed before July 19, 1948, while making registration mandatory for those who arrived after that date.